And so: it was late 1988, early 1989. Israel had a national unity government headed by Yitzhak Shamir, with Yitzhak Rabin as its defense minister. The director of the Mossad at the time, Nahum Admoni, agreed with the prime minister that he would be completing his tenure and recommended that I be the one to replace him. I had only really met the prime minister during the last year of Admoni's term, but because neither of us is a man of many words I feared that his impression of me was only superficial. Defense Minister Yitzhak Rabin's candidate for the job was the head of Military Intelligence, Amnon Lipkin-Shahak, a decorated general with vast experience and many achievements under his belt.

A few days before the prime minister was to decide which of the candidates to choose, I was in Germany in the midst of an operation to thwart an attack by the PFLP against an American air base in Germany. The warning of the attack had been conveyed to us from Mossad sources, and the Germans therefore agreed that the operation would be managed by the Mossad in coordination with them. Because the target of the attack was American, the Americans were also brought into the picture, but to their chagrin, neither we nor the Germans agreed to hand the operation over to them, and they remained in the background.

After considerable deliberation, I called Nahum Admoni in Israel and asked him to arrange a meeting for me with the prime minister, to which I would arrive directly from Germany only to immediately return there in less than twenty-four hours. Nahum agreed. My meeting with the prime minister was short and to the point; I presented him with the reasons I thought I deserved to be appointed to the job. Toward the end of the meeting, as an aside, I told him that if I was not chosen I planned on retiring. I certainly did not intend this as a threat, heaven forbid; I meant only to draw his attention to the fact that in such a case he would have to appoint both a new director and a new deputy director of the Mossad.

The prime minister appointed me to the post. Some time later I heard from one of his associates that after my meeting with him he had said something along the lines of "Who is this Shavit and who the hell does he think he is?" This, of course, was related to my comment about retiring were I not chosen for the job. Still, this episode did not have any effect on the prime minister's practical judgment or on the relationship that developed between us later on.